Product / Project Translator



THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Find out what they need to decide. Give them a useful answer without promising work you cannot yet describe.

Nic Payne

For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

START WITH A REAL SITUATION. DECIDE WHAT HAPPENS NEXT.

“Can you just give me the final requirements?”

Someone needs a feature list, a date, or a budget while you’re still finding things out. Let’s understand what they need the answer for, then work out what you can usefully offer now.

Find the decision behind the question

Finance may need to reserve money. Sales may need to tell a customer when to expect something. Another team may need to plan its work. Ask rather than guessing.

Say what you can answer now

If the work is understood and the team can give a reliable date, use it. If an important question is still open, explain exactly what it is.

Offer a useful next step

Perhaps you can agree to test two booking designs with customers in the next two weeks, then bring a build estimate to Finance. Name the work, the limit, and what they will be able to decide afterward.

Write a reply you would actually say

The Lab helps you check the request, prepare a commitment, and write the response. You don’t need to teach someone product-management vocabulary before helping them plan.

Try: “What do you need the feature list for? Which decision are you trying to make, and when do you need to make it?”

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

You can be frustrated and still be curious.

When someone asks for details you don't have yet, it can be hard to know what to say. They may be trying to make a decision of their own. Let's start by finding out what it is.

What actually happened?

Start with what was said or done. "They asked for Friday" tells us what happened. "They don't care about the team" is an explanation you may have added. What could you ask to find out what's behind the request?

Why do you care?

Who would be better off if this worked? Perhaps a customer could stop chasing an answer, or your team could finish something it promised. Say why that matters to you, and ask what matters to the other person too.

What would better look like?

Imagine the next few weeks going well. What would people be doing differently? Describe that in ordinary words, then ask the other person what they would add or change.

Keep these notes to yourself

These questions are for your own thinking; you can answer them without typing. If you use the Lab's private notes, they stay only in the open tab. They aren't saved or exported, and disappear when you refresh or leave.

An opening you can adapt: "I want us to find a way through this. Can we look at what is happening and work out what to do next?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Ask what they will use the answer for.

You may have an idea of why they're asking. A quick question can help you check it before you spend time on the answer.

"We need final requirements"

"Which decision depends on that list? Do you need to reserve money, agree a contract, or get another team ready?" Find out which details need to be settled now.

"We need a firm date"

"Who is waiting for it, and what have they been told?" Ask the team for its current delivery estimate and what could change it.

"We need the full roadmap"

"How far ahead do you need to plan, and what will you use it for?" Explain which work is agreed, which is only a possibility, and when you'll know more.

Record what they actually confirm

If you haven't asked yet, jot down the question you want to ask. You can add their answer after you have spoken; for now, keep your guess separate from what they've confirmed.

You're looking for an answer that helps them make their decision. Check that you understand it before writing the response.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What can we promise at this point?

You can still give someone a useful answer while you're learning. Let's work out what you can do now, what it will help you find out, and when you'll come back to them.

Start with what you know

For example, customers currently phone to book repairs. There are two possible online designs. Neither has been tried with customers.

Name the question that matters

Can customers complete a booking using either design? How much work would the better one take to build? Say how you'll find out.

Propose the work and its limits

Ask to spend up to $5,000 over two weeks to try both designs with five customers and get an Engineering estimate. Name who does each part. Those are fictional example amounts, not recommended defaults.

Explain what comes afterward

Bring the findings and estimate to Finance. Ask whether to fund the build, change the idea, or stop. Don't promise a finished service when you're only promising a customer test.

A useful commitment says what you'll do, who will do it, how much time or money you'll use, and when the other person will hear back.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Say it as you would in the meeting.

Start with what they need. Then explain what you can offer and ask for the decision you need.

Show that you heard them

“You need a spending limit by Thursday.” Use the need they confirmed, rather than an explanation you invented.

Make a concrete offer

“Could we set aside up to $5,000 for two weeks to try both booking designs with five customers and check the build work with Engineering?”

Explain what they will get back

“We’ll bring you the results, an estimate, and a recommendation before asking you to pay for the full build.”

Ask for a response

“Would that give you enough to make Thursday's decision?” Let them tell you if the offer doesn’t meet their need. Revise it together.

Read the message aloud. If you would not say a phrase in conversation, find the words you would use.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Keep working on the actual question.

Sometimes the first offer won't be enough. Ask what is missing.

"Just give me the date"

If the team has a reliable estimate for the agreed work, share it with its assumptions. Otherwise say what needs checking and when you can return with an estimate. Use Deadline Reset if a date has already been promised.

"We can't approve an open-ended budget"

Agree a maximum spend and a stopping point. Explain what that money buys and what will still be unknown. The person paying can change or decline the proposal.

"We need to tell the customer something"

Work with the person responsible for that customer. State what is available, what is still being checked, and when the next update will come. Check any existing contractual promise.

"Why does the plan keep changing?"

Explain what you learned and how it changed the plan. If you also missed something or didn't keep people updated, acknowledge that and agree how you'll keep them informed from here.

Try: "I want to give you something you can plan around. Which part of this still leaves you unable to make the decision?"

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Finance needs a budget by Thursday.

Fictional example: the finance director asks for the final feature list for an online repair-booking service. Customers haven't tried either proposed design yet.

The product manager asks why

Finance needs a spending limit by Thursday. They don't need every screen agreed. The product manager checks that understanding before proposing a smaller first spend.

The proposed commitment

Propose spending up to $5,000 over two weeks to let five customers try both designs and ask Engineering what each would take to build. The product manager arranges the customer sessions; the engineering lead estimates the build work.

The reply

You need a budget by Thursday. Could we approve up to $5,000 for two weeks of customer testing first? Then we can show you which design works and what it would take to build before you commit to the full cost.

What happens next

In this example, Finance approves the limited spend on Thursday. The product manager books the customer sessions and the review two weeks later. Funding for the full build is still undecided. The Lab example starts before approval.

Finance can plan the immediate spend. The team knows what to test. Nobody has pretended that the final design or full delivery date is already known.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

Bring the sentence you heard.

You can prepare the reply before the conversation and update it after you have checked what the other person needs.

The request

Record their words, who asked, and what they need to decide. The starter buttons can help you begin; edit the wording to match your situation.

What they need

Choose the reason they need an answer, record what they confirmed, and name anything you still need to check. Preview What They Need if you want to review your understanding.

What we can promise

Write what you know, what is still uncertain, and what you can offer now. Include the time, money, and other limits. Preview Proposed Commitment.

Your reply

Write the short spoken version if useful, then the message. Name the decision you need and when. Preview Your Reply as a proposal. Return after the conversation to record the answer and the next action.

Load Examples shows the fictional booking-service case. Use your own facts before sharing a document.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

What happened after the conversation?

Once you have talked, come back and see what changed. What helped, what still needs attention, and who needs to hear from you?

Follow up

Bring the promised findings on the agreed date. Ask whether they helped the person make the decision. If you misunderstood the need or promised something too vague, revise the offer and check it with them.

Try saying it out loud

Read your message aloud. Does it sound like you? If a phrase feels awkward, use the words you'd say in the meeting. Someone you trust can help you spot anything that's hard to follow.

Keep the record

Copy, download, or print anything you need to keep. Shared answers save in this browser on this device; they don't follow you to another device. Private notes aren't saved. Export before clearing a draft or browser data.

Check what happened

Was the decision understood? Did someone act? Did the change help the people it was meant to help? If nobody responded, find out who can decide and agree when to ask again. Silence doesn't mean yes.

You don't have to fix the whole organization in one conversation. Leave knowing what happens next, who will do it, and when you'll check back.

Reading and reflection: see the companion at the end of this Guide >

The thinking behind the tool.

Holistic Shaping asks what work is doing to people, as well as what people are doing at work. These short notes connect the Guide to Nic's teaching and a few practical sources. Read what helps with the situation in front of you. Links open the original resources.

Two maps you can return to

Cultural Orbital Mechanics
Nic Payne / Holistic Shaping · Framework resource

How identity, relationships, and shared vision give rise to culture—and how that culture shapes people in return.

Holistic Impact Depth
Nic Payne / Holistic Shaping · Framework resource

Use the tree and five areas of health to look at what everyday work is doing to people.

Back in the Guide

CHAPTER 01

Find out what their words mean to them.

In Nic's writing on shared language, a practical constraint can be a contribution to the idea. 'Final requirements' might mean Finance needs to know what funding would cover. Ask what decision the request serves before explaining your preferred way of working.

Worth asking: What do they need to decide, and what would help them decide it?

Stop Chasing Psychological Safety
Nic Payne · Article

CHAPTER 02

Stay curious when the wording irritates you.

It is easy to hear a project word and prepare a lecture about Product. Notice the person using it. They have work, pressures, and responsibilities of their own. Nic's bowl metaphor asks what kind of attention we bring to the relationship and whether we leave room to be changed by it.

Worth asking: What might you understand if you let them finish explaining the request?

Leadership as bowl, water, and current
Nic Payne · Video · start at 4:19

Every leader needs contact lenses
Nic Payne · Substack Note

The Mirror Move
Nic Payne / Rebel Leaders · Codex practice

CHAPTER 04

Give uncertainty a useful next step.

You can make a real commitment without promising an answer you do not yet have. Say which question you will check, how, and by when. Teresa Torres's assumption-testing guide helps narrow that question. Nic's writing on certainty explains why a polished plan should not replace judgment.

Worth asking: Which belief must you check before asking people to commit to the whole build?

The Search For Unapologetic Impracticality In Leadership: Part II - The Seduction of Certainty
Nic Payne · Article

Assumption Testing: Everything You Need to Know to Get Started
Teresa Torres · Author's practical article

CHAPTER 05

Read your reply out loud.

"To lead differently, we must learn to speak a different language."

Nic Payne · The words we use for people

Nic's Note on the words we inherit asks us to notice when language hides the person. Name the customer waiting for a repair, the developer checking the change, and the colleague who needs a funding decision. If a sentence sounds like something nobody would say, rewrite it before sending.

Worth asking: Could the person receiving this explain what you are offering and what you need from them?

The words we use for people
Nic Payne · Substack Note

CHAPTER 06

Does your reply leave them able to participate?

Use HID to consider what repeated exchanges like this do to people. A correction can leave someone embarrassed and less willing to ask. A clear explanation can help both of you learn the work, make better judgments, and build trust. Be specific about what you can offer, and invite them to tell you what is still missing.

Worth asking: Can they question or change your proposal without being made to feel foolish?

Holistic Impact Depth
Nic Payne / Holistic Shaping · Framework resource

CHAPTER 09

Build a shared way to ask and answer.

After the immediate request, ask what you now understand about each other's work. Keep the explanation and decision where the next person can find them. Cultural Orbital Mechanics helps trace how repeated encounters shape identity and relationship—and what becomes normal between teams.

Worth asking: Will the next request be easier because of what you learned together?

Cultural Orbital Mechanics
Nic Payne / Holistic Shaping · Framework resource

Do Your Replacement a Favor
Nic Payne · Article

Explore Nic's articles, video, and the complete reading library.

The notes apply the teaching to these situations. They are not quotations unless marked. The health reflection is optional; you do not need to record or share personal information.